

NOOR POST

One of fourteen. Open it on the day.



FOR

[Child's name]



Noor Post
[Return address — not set]

ENVELOPE 14 • DHUL
HIJJAH • INSIDE THE FLAP

Open together.

🕒 **About twenty-five minutes**

● is the grown-up. ○ is you.

- 1 The letter — read it out loud, ● and ○ taking turns
- 2 The hadith card
- 3 The prints
- 4 Open the case file
- 5 The stickers
- 6 The postcard

FACT PANEL

Imam Muhammad al-Jawad

(peace be upon him)

B. 195 AH, MEDINA • D. 220 AH, BAGHDAD

- **Where and when.** Medina, and Baghdad, and back, and Baghdad again. He was summoned more than once, and the second time he did not leave.
- **Who was ruling.** The Abbasid caliphs — al-Ma'mun, who staged the examination and married him to his daughter, and then al-Mu'tasim after him.
- **The imamate.** About seventeen years, from 203 AH, **from the age of about eight.** The youngest of the fourteen to take it while present, and the fact the whole envelope turns on.
- **What he left.** Answers given young and recorded because people came specifically to test him, and a network of representatives kept running from a very exposed position. **He died at about twenty-five, and there is more material from him than from men who lived twice as long.**
- **Umm al-Fadl.** The daughter of the caliph al-Ma'mun, married to him after the examination — a marriage arranged by an empire that could not decide whether it wanted this family destroyed or attached.
- **Elsewhere in the world.** In the same years, in Britain, small kingdoms that had spent centuries fighting each other were being pushed together into one under the pressure of raids from the sea.

He died in Baghdad in 220 AH, aged about twenty-five. Shia accounts hold that he was killed on the orders of the caliph al-Mu'tasim.

ENVELOPE 14 • DHUL HIJJAH

The Room Full of Grown-Ups



• is the grown-up • ○ is you • ●○ is together

- The room was full and the seats had been arranged carefully. Senior men, the kind who are introduced by their titles. The chief judge of the empire was there, and he had been asked to do the questioning.

○ Question who?

- A boy. About eight years old. Younger than you.

○ Eight?

- His father had died and everything had come to him, and there were a great many people who thought that was ridiculous, and said so, and the caliph decided to settle it in public. So a date was set, and word went round, and people came to watch.

○ Watch what?

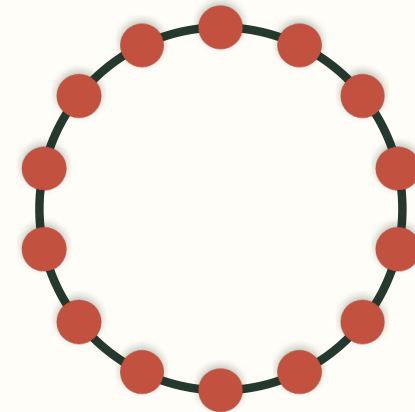
- Watch a child be asked a hard question in front of a room, by the best-known lawyer in the empire, with everyone present outranking him in age, in office, and in every way a room can be ranked.
- Nobody in that room was expecting him to answer. That is the part to hold on to. They were expecting to watch a boy go quiet.

○ What did they ask?

- A question about the law with a lot of branches in it — the kind that sounds like one question and is actually about six, and the trap is that whichever one you answer, you have answered the wrong one.
- **How would you feel standing there? Say it out loud before we go on.**
- And he did something nobody had prepared for. He did not answer it. He took the question apart, out loud, into all the different cases it was hiding — if it is this, then this; if it is that, then that — and then he turned it round and asked the judge which one of them he actually meant.
- The judge had to pick. The whole room heard him have to pick.
- So here is what I want you to work out, and the answer is sealed in this envelope. Not what he said. Why the room existed at all.
- The caliph had an empire to run. He set aside a day, filled a hall, and put his own chief judge up against a boy of eight.

SAY THIS ONE TOGETHER

•○
**Why go to all that
trouble to test a child?**



Then the hadith card.

IMAM AL-JAWAD SAID

**“To show a matter before
preparing for it properly is
spoilng it.”**

Imam al-Jawad

NOOR POST · THE FOURTEEN

The chain

Every card in this box is one link. Lay all fourteen in order and the chain runs from the Prophet to the last of the twelve, each one passing on what was given.



Fourteen segments · historical order

Tuhaf al-Uqul, short maxims, no. 12. Translated by Badr Shahin,
Ansariyan Publications, Qum.

The question

Why go to all that trouble to test a child?

Five evidence cards. Read them in any order. Then say your answer out loud, before anyone opens the sealed card.



EVIDENCE

1

It was public and it was announced. Seats, an audience, a date. Nobody was doing this quietly.

EVIDENCE

2

The questioner was the chief judge — the most senior legal figure available. Not a scholar sent along; the top man.



EVIDENCE

3

The caliph, al-Ma'mun, arranged it. He had already decided to marry his own daughter to the boy.



EVIDENCE

4

The question had many branches.
Whichever branch you answer, you can be
told you answered the wrong one.

EVIDENCE

5

A great many people were saying openly that a child could not hold that position. That is what the day was about, and everyone knew it.



Sealed

Parent: open this only when the child has committed to an answer. Not before.

THE ANSWER

The room was not there to find out whether he knew things. It was there to settle something in public, and the caliph could not lose either way.

Work through both outcomes. **If the boy fails**, it is over — in front of witnesses, with the empire's chief judge as the man who did it, and nobody can ever say it was done in a back room. The claim ends cheaply and the caliph never has to touch anybody.

If the boy passes, the caliph has a different prize. Evidence 3 is the giveaway: the marriage was already decided. A recognised, publicly-proven son-in-law is somebody you have brought inside your own house — where he can be watched, and where anything he does reflects on you, and where his standing is partly yours.

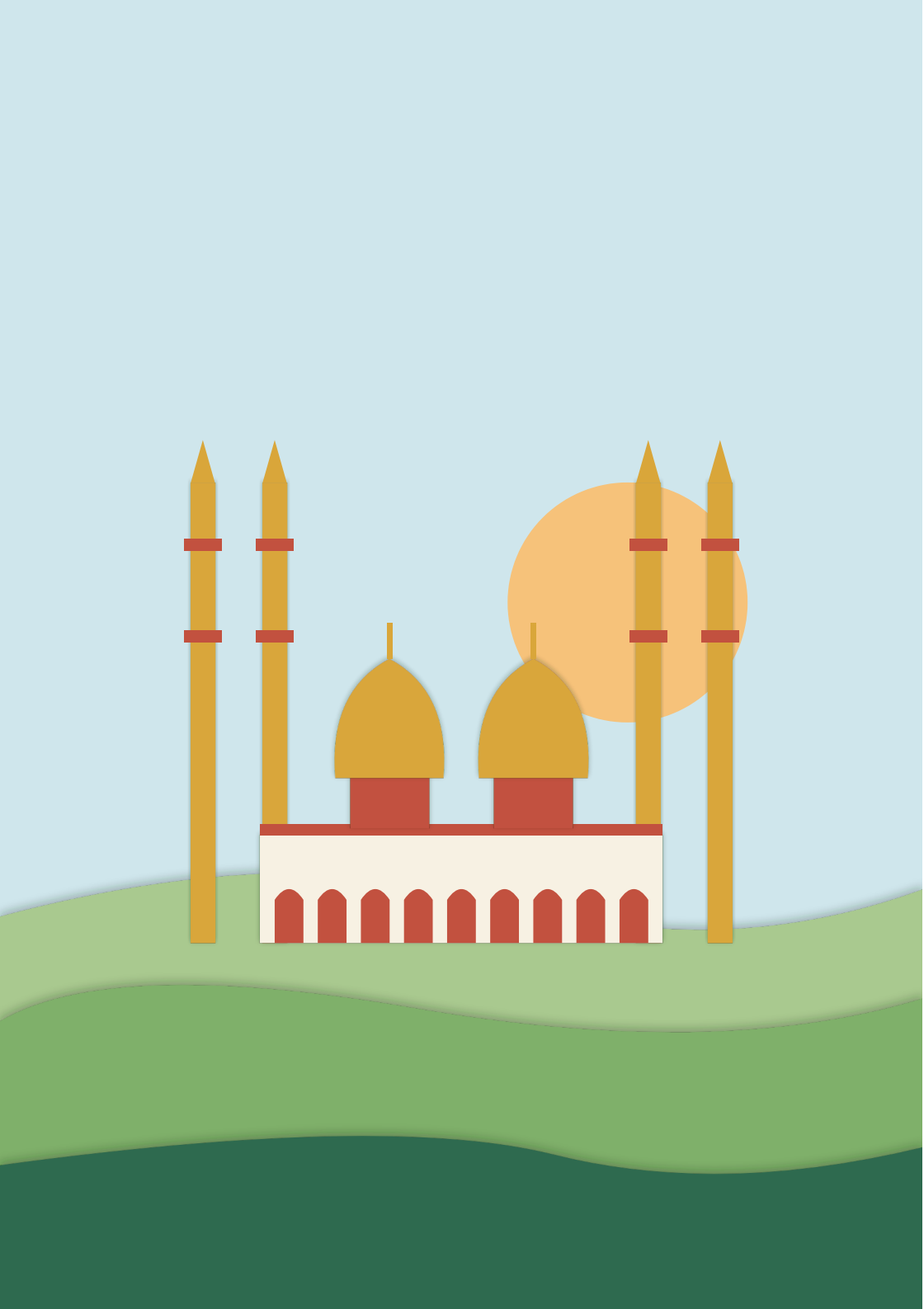
That is why it was public. A private test has no use to anybody.

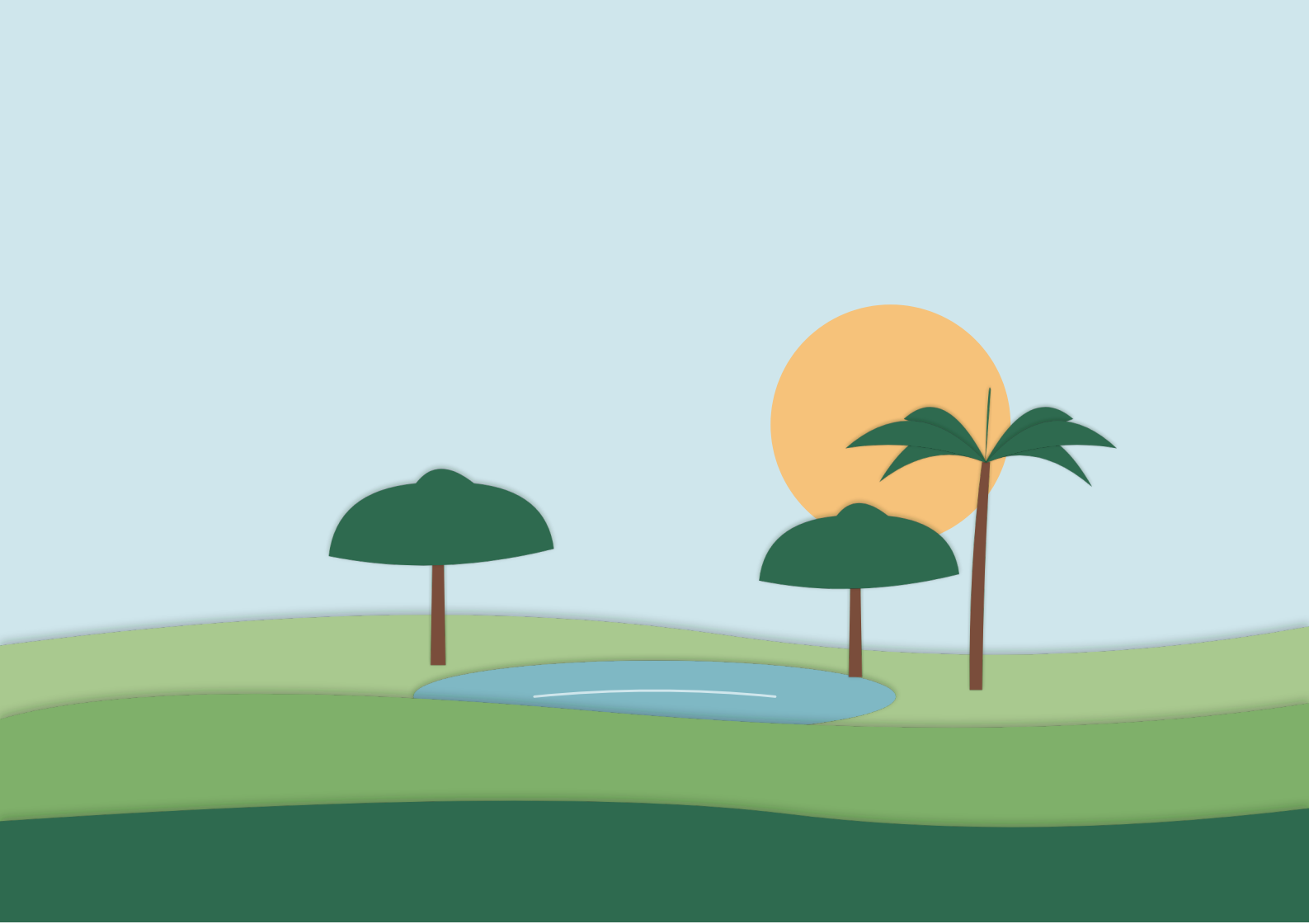
And this is why what he did was better than a right answer. He did not take the question as offered — he pulled it into its separate cases and handed the choice back to the judge.

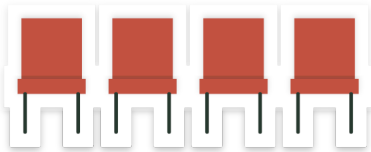
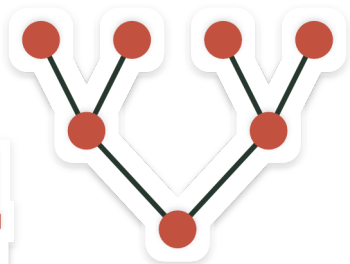
Anyone can memorise answers. He showed method, in front of a room assembled to prove he had none, and the chief judge of the empire had to stand there and pick a branch.

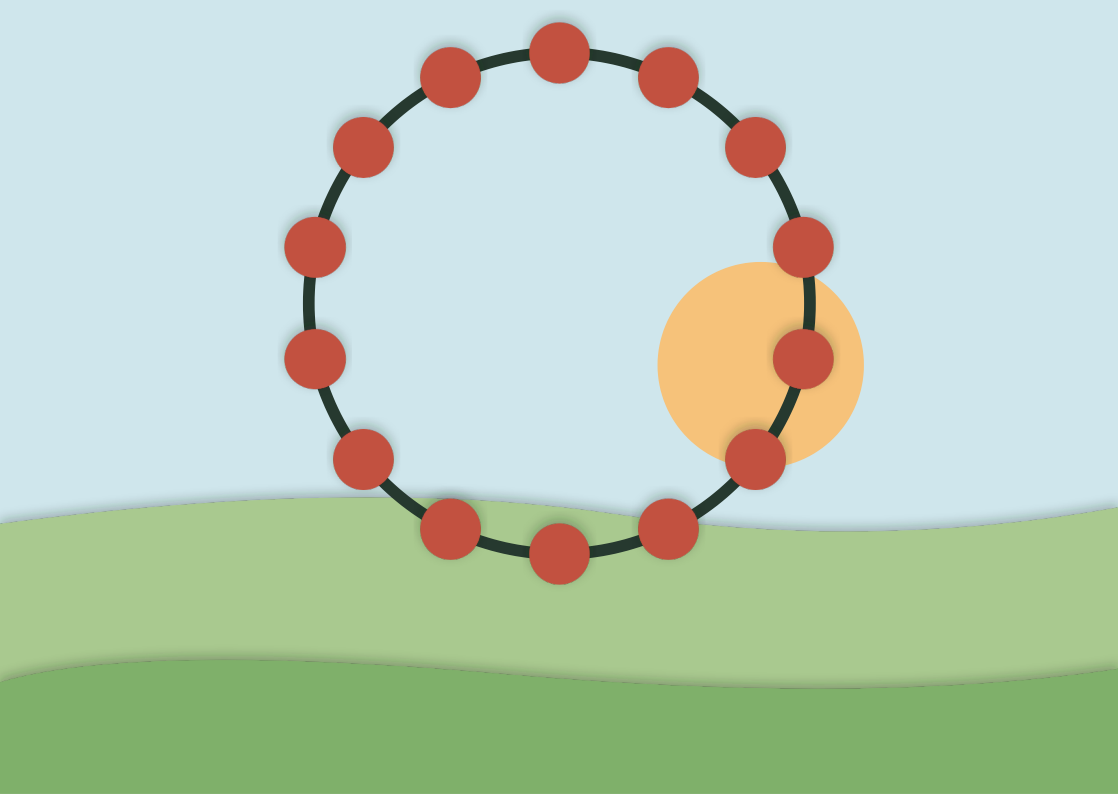
After that day, the question of whether he was too young stopped being asked out loud.











**We opened this one
together.**

● _____

○ _____

Post it back to us, or keep it. Either is right.

STAMP

Noor Post

[Return address — not set]

